

She was shocked at the cost of childcare. She finally selected what she thought would be the best childcare center, but it would cost them a good chunk of money each week.

As the weeks passed, she and Ben continued to argue about money. Naomi believed she was a slave to Ben's impulses. He often bought things he wanted, such as a new television or a better CD player, but then there was no money for needed clothes or to treat themselves to eating out. And he often took money from the ATM but failed to deduct the amount from the checkbook. Finally, she decided that she would keep a portion of her paycheck for herself. Instead of bringing the check home as she had in the past, she would stop at the bank and deposit it, taking out the money she needed.

Ben was furious when she told him about it. "Naomi, you can't do that," he argued. "There won't be enough money to pay all the bills."

"Then they will have to go unpaid," Naomi retorted. "I'm not going to worry about it anymore. You never paid my dad back for his loan, and I'm going to start paying him back something every month. Ben, you act like an irresponsible child. I'm sick and tired of working all day and never being able to spend any of my own money."

"Well, if it's your money, why don't you just keep it yourself, and I'll keep my money!" Ben shouted as he stormed out of the room.

"Fine!" Naomi shouted back as he slammed the door.

Naomi spent the next two hours drawing up a budget, dividing their respective expenses. She decided that she should pay for the baby's childcare, her transportation, and a fourth of the utilities.

The next day she left work a little early so that she could go to the bank and open a checking account in her name. That evening she informed Ben that she had decided to keep her money and pay her own bills. She handed him a copy of the division of expenses that she had drawn up.